At the time of Pakistan's founding there were already 70 million Muslims living within what became the borders of the new nation. Because Pakistan was contoured to include the Muslim majority regions of colonial India the new country consisted of two separate pieces of territory—West and East Pakistan—divided by 1000 miles of land belonging to India. Notably, the greatest support for the country's creation came from Muslims living outside of the regions that became modern day Pakistan.[9] The government was based in West Pakistan, which was at once less densely populated and more heterogeneous than its Eastern counterpart. Hindus and Muslims alike spoke Bengali in East Pakistan, which in 1971 seceded to form Bangladesh. In contrast, West Pakistan drew together the four provinces of Punjab, Sindh, Balochistan and the North-West Frontier Province [NWFP, now known as Khyber Pakhtunkhwa] along with the Federally Administered Tribal Areas [FATA or Tribal Areas].[10] Not only was West Pakistan home to people of different ethnicities, languages and cultures. It also had to absorb the approximately nine million Muslims, known as Mohajirs, who left India after Partition. Many of those who attempted the journey did not survive the furious communal violence that accompanied it. Hafiz Saeed, the man chosen to lead Lashkar at its founding, was born in post-Partition Pakistan. But thirty-six members of his family and clan were killed during their attempt to emigrate from India.[11]

Not long after independence Bengalis in East Pakistan were demanding Bengali as a national language. Meanwhile Sindhis, Pashtuns [the dominant ethnicity in the NWFP and FATA] and Balochs in West Pakistan were protesting over the fact that Punjabis and Mohajirs dominated the civil services and military officer corps. Among all of these ethnic entities, only Punjab never pressed for greater autonomy. This fact is explained by the province's predominant position within Pakistan: Punjabis are over-represented in the civil bureaucracy as well as in the army. Whether ruled by civilians or the military, the central government historically has been unrepresentative of the different ethno-linguistic groups brought together by Partition. Pakistan's central leadership feared disunity resulting from political opposition would weaken the country and leave it vulnerable to India. In response, it promoted Islamic unity to undercut competing ethno-nationalisms and bind the country together. The central government also instrumentalized hostility toward India as a means of enhancing national